Phoenix United Basketball Development Club

CHILD SAFETY OFFICER GUIDE

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CONTENTS

PURPOSE 2
INTRODUCTION 2
ABOUT THE ROLE 3
CORE RESPONSIBILITIES 3
Promote a Child Safe Culture 3
Support and Educate Volunteers 3
Respond to Concerns 3
Escalate When Required 3
Keep Records 4
AUDITING OR WORKING WITH CHILDREN CHECKS (WWCC) 4
NON-COMPLIANCE 4
POLICY 5
REPORTING 5
HELPFUL CONTACTS 6
TIPS FOR SUCCESS 6
CONCLUSION 6
CHILD SAFETY CONCERN FORM 7

PURPOSE

The purpose of this guide is to assist the volunteer non committee role of Child Safety Officer (CSO) to carry out their duties at Phoenix. Please remember, your committee is always here to provide guidance and support. We also welcome your feedback as we work together, as volunteers, to deliver the best experience for our junior players and their families.

This guide is being implemented for the 1st time, and we greatly appreciate any feedback on how we can make it better. Please send to hello@bendigophoenix.org.au.

INTRODUCTION

The safety and wellbeing of our junior players is our highest priority at the Club. We are committed to providing a child-safe, inclusive, and respectful environment where all children and young people feel supported and protected.

The Club has adopted and is committed to the Bendigo Basketball Association (BBA) Child Protection Policy. This guides our actions and sets clear expectations for all members, volunteers, and families. As part of putting this policy

into practice, we appoint a **Child Safety Officer (CSO)** each year to act as a key contact and champion for child safety across the club.

This guide supports the Child Safety Officer by outlining their role, responsibilities, and practical steps to help promote a culture of safety, respond to concerns, and assist children, families, and volunteers.

The role is not about managing everything alone—but about being a supportive, informed presence who helps ensure our club meets its obligations under the **Victorian Child Safe Standards** and the **Basketball Victoria Member Protection Policy**.

This guide is designed to be clear, practical, and easy to follow—whether you're stepping into the role for the first time or continuing from a previous season.

ABOUT THE ROLE

The Child Safety Officer (CSO) is a dedicated person within the club who helps ensure children and young people feel safe, respected, and supported. This is a **non-committee role** appointed at the AGM each year.

The CSO is the **first point of contact** for child safety concerns and plays a key role in promoting a culture of safety and inclusion, as well as policy development and compliance.

CORE RESPONSIBILITIES

Promote a Child Safe Culture

- Be visible and approachable to children, families, and volunteers.
- Support a positive and respectful club environment.
- Share information about child safety, including club policies, Codes of Conduct, and complaint processes.

Support and Educate Volunteers

- Encourage coaches, managers, and volunteers to complete free child safety training as highlighted in the Club's Child Safety policy.
- Remind team staff to follow supervision, communication, and inclusion best practices.
- Help deliver a short child safety briefing at the start of each season.

Respond to Concerns

- Be available to receive concerns, complaints, or disclosures from children or adults.
- Handle concerns confidentially and with care, always putting the child's safety first.
- Follow the club's Reporting and Complaint Procedure.

Escalate When Required

If the concern involves harm, abuse, or serious misconduct, escalate to:

- Club President, committee member or Committee (if appropriate)
- Basketball Victoria Integrity Unit
- Victoria Police or Child Protection (in serious or urgent cases)

Keep Records

- Record concerns and actions taken using the club's internal **Child Safety Concern Form**.
- Store all records securely in the club's Google Drive, with access limited to authorised Office Bearers. If the concern involves an Office Bearer, consult with a different Office Bearer to determine an appropriate and secure location for storing the record. Only share documentation on a strict need-to-know basis.

AUDITING OR WORKING WITH CHILDREN CHECKS (WWCC)

The CSO is responsible for ensuring all volunteers and team officials hold valid Working with Children Checks (WWCCs) and are properly registered with the Club before engaging in any child-related duties.

Most volunteers cannot complete PlayHQ registration without a valid WWCC linked to the Club. The CSO should:

- Conduct pre-season audits using PlayHQ reports (available from office bearers) to confirm that all required volunteers are correctly registered and hold current WWCCs.
- **Use the Victorian Government WWCC Status Checker** to verify WWCC numbers provided during PlayHQ registration are valid.
    - https://www.workingwithchildren.vic.gov.au/
    - Confirm that checks are current, approved, and linked to the Club as a volunteer organisation.
- Perform random spot checks of physical WWCC cards may still be conducted if any discrepancies arise or for returning volunteers with gaps in registration. These checks help maintain a safe environment and ensure the Club meets its obligations under the Child Safe Standards.

NON-COMPLIANCE

If a volunteer or team official is found to have an **expired WWCC or incomplete PlayHQ registration**, the following steps must be taken:

1. Immediate Action:

- Ask the individual to step down from all child-related duties until the issue is resolved. Inform them this is a non-negotiable legal and Club requirement.

2. Notify the Committee

- Report the matter to the Club President and Child Safety Officer (if not already involved).
- Document:
    - Name and role of the individual

- Nature of the non-compliance (expired WWCC, incomplete PlayHQ registration)
- Actions taken
- Communications with the individual

3. Provide Instructions for Rectification

- Direct the individual to:
  - Apply for or renew their WWCC at workingwithchildren.vic.gov.au
  - Link Phoenix Basketball Club as a volunteer organisation
  - Complete or update PlayHQ registration if not listed

4. Escalate if Required

- If the individual refuses to comply or continues in their role without a valid WWCC or registration:
  - Escalate to Basketball Victoria or remove them from all Club-sanctioned activities.
  - For serious or repeated breaches, access to training venues or game-day benches may be restricted, and the matter reported to Child Safe Victoria or other governing bodies.

Note: With PlayHQ's strengthened WWCC enforcement, bypassing checks is unlikely, but the CSO should continue to support volunteers to resolve any registration or WWCC issues promptly.

POLICY

While the Club currently adopts the league's Child Protection Policy. The club is committed to developing its own tailored Child Safety Policy with the help of the CSO to better reflect our specific environment and needs. Until then, the league's policy remains our guiding framework.

REPORTING

The CSO should provide regular updates to the Committee to ensure ongoing compliance and safety within the Club. With PlayHQ's strengthened WWCC validation, the CSO can now rely on system reports to confirm that all volunteers and team officials hold valid WWCCs and are correctly registered.

Reports to the Committee may include:

- Results of **pre-season audits** using PlayHQ to verify WWCCs and registration status.
- Identification of any volunteers or team officials needing support to complete or update their WWCC or PlayHQ registration.
- Updates on child safety training completed by volunteers.

- Any child safety incidents reported, along with how they were managed or resolved.
- Recommendations for improvements to child safety policies or practices.

If the CSO is unable to attend a Committee meeting, written updates can be provided to the Club Secretary or President in advance.

HELPFUL CONTACTS

Service	Contact Info
Bendigo Basketball Association	Sam Cartwright, BBA Basketball Manager, 0427 937 020
Basketball Victoria Integrity Unit	integrity@basketballvictoria.com.au
Victoria Police (Emergency)	000
Child Protection – Central Intake	1800 675 598
Child Safety Standards Info	ccyp.vic.gov.au

TIPS FOR SUCCESS

- Build trust with players and families by being visible and friendly.
- Remind kids it's OK to speak up if they feel unsafe or uncomfortable.
- Partner with coaches and team managers—they're your eyes and ears on the ground.
- Keep calm and supportive if a child discloses something. Don't promise secrecy—let them know you'll help.

CONCLUSION

Your role as Child Safety Officer is vital in upholding the wellbeing and protection of every child involved in the Club. By promoting safe practices, supporting volunteers, and responding to concerns with care and integrity, you help create a trusted, inclusive environment where young people can thrive—on and off the court.

CHILD SAFETY CONCERN FORM

(Confidential – Internal Use Only)

Section 1 – Reporter Details	
Name	
Role	
Mobile	
Email	
Date of Report	

Section 2 – Child/Young Person Details			
Name			
Age		**Gender**	
Team (if applicable)			

Section 3 – Concern Details			
Date Incident/Concern		**Time of Incident/Concern**	
Location			
Type of Concern (tick all that apply)			
Behaviour of adult		Behaviour of child	
Possible risk of harm		Disclosure by child	
Physical indicators (injuries/marks)		Other (please describe)	
Description of Concern (factual only, no opinions)			
Exact Words of Child/Young Person (if disclosed)			

Section 4 – Immediate Action Taken			
First aid provided		Removed from situation	
Reported to police (000)		Reported to Child Protection / Child Safety agency	
Contacted parent/guardian		Other	
Details of action taken			

Section 5 – Escalation & Internal Notification				
Reported to Club Child Safety Officer			Yes	No
Name of Child Safety Officer				
Date		**Time**		
Further Action Required			Yes	No
If Yes, outline				

Section 6 – Sign-Off			
Reporter Signature		**Date**	
Club Child Safey Officer Signature		**Date**	

Confidentiality Notice: *This form must be stored securely and only shared with those directly responsible for child safety compliance (e.g., Child Safety Officer, Club President, relevant authorities).*